

Lesson 8: In It for the Long-Haul

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How many times have you heard it said before, “It’s a marathon, not a sprint!” or “Slow and steady wins the race?”

Too many?

Well, in the case of the workplace it couldn’t be more true. When it comes to your career, you have to pace yourself for “the long haul,” as they say.

A lot of people don’t think of it this way – they dive in straight out of college – or maybe you’ve just started a new career and a new chapter and you’re rearing to go. Long nights, stolen weekends, a little here and a little there. No detail is too small, no work trip unimportant.

This works for a while. Maybe it even works for years. But it *does* catch up with you. It catches up to all of us!

The fact is, there are a few strategic principles to staying in it for the long haul and making your career go the distance. This involves picking your battles and avoiding burnout.

First, picking your battles. You have to know which battles to fight, and which to leave to someone else. Which projects need 100% of your time and energy, and how to move on or delegate. There is an art to this – it does not come naturally.

Second, avoiding burnout. According to research, women are statistically more likely to report burnout than men – nearly *half* of all women surveyed by some reports. And according to the American Psychological Association, 76% of adults said they have experienced health impacts due to stress in the prior month.

76 percent!

Women are at a higher risk than men for several reasons – one is the headwinds they face in their careers, which we’ve already outlined here. The second is the fact that women are more likely to take on “hidden work” – work that is prep work or behind the scenes, work that contributes to the office culture but not the bottom line. And the third is the simple fact that women face more caregiving responsibilities at home than men – traditionally, that is. When you go home and your work doesn’t “stop” and you keep running until bedtime, it’s no wonder you’re at a higher risk.

So, what can you do to avoid burnout and stay in it for the long haul? An ounce of prevention is worth a pound of cure here.

The first is being aware of the stages of burnout and know that it has the tendency to creep up. Stress manifests itself in three categories:

Acute stress is short-term, like a stressful month or two buying a house or working on a one-time project.

Episodic stress is short term, but frequent, like a tax accountant during busy season or realtor during the peak summer months.

Finally, chronic stress is long-term or ongoing stress that lasts longer than 6 months.

You do *not* want to live in the chronic stress zone, especially as mother, wife, or simply as a human being prioritizing their health and well-being.

So, what can you do to avoid burnout?

Be mindful of stress and how it manifests itself in your life and your workday. All types of stress are not the same, some are good, some are bad, but too much of any of it will affect your health and ultimately your career.

Next, identify triggers. The farther you go in your career, the better you'll be able to recognize your own personal triggers and how to avoid them.

Speak up about the stress. Know when to speak up and when to power through. Don't be afraid to stand up for the boundaries you need to keep things on the rails in your career. Remember – *marathon*, not a sprint!

And finally, make de-stressing an intentional part of your workday and work week. You heard me – it's not going to come naturally! Our human instinct is to either be "on," running around, multi-tasking, trying to do all the things, or "off," where we are in front of the TV at a long hard day, making poor diet choices, or worse – too tired to leave the house or engage in time with family.

De-stressing can look like several different things to different people, and we won't get in to them all in this video – sometimes it's intentional breaks during the day. Sometimes it's a 20 min walk after work to reset your mind. Sometimes it's a hot shower with some aromatherapy, time at the gym, happy hour with friends, spending time in the evening reading to your son or daughter. Whatever it is for you, these things are natural speed bumps in your day for a reason to slow things down and calm you down to keep you optimized and ready for the next workday.

So, with that in mind, let's learn more about how we can win the marathon, or in Pat's case, the championship, without sacrificing the things we enjoy and the unique things that make you, YOU.

You've got this! Let's take a closer look.